

IDENTITY PARADE

Another South Asian bride comes to the land of plenty and another novel of immigrant anxiety is born



THE IMMIGRANT
by MANJU KAPUR
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■ By Brinda Bose

The *Immigrant* is a lucid, perceptive and sympathetic tale of Nina, a college lecturer who is transported, one unremarkable day, from the bustle and struggle of an educated middle-class existence in New Delhi to the frosty comfort of small-town Halifax, Canada, by virtue of an arranged marriage. It re-visits, in many ways, what has often been regurgitated over the past quarter-century as the quintessential story of a South Asian immigrant bride setting foot in the North American land of plenty—and the title, like Manju Kapur's earlier similarly cryptic signposts for her novels on women's lives, signals this spotlighting of the diasporic condition. In other words, what you see is what you get. And there are more clues on the cover: the half-silhouetted, slender woman barefoot in a skirt holding a coffee mug as she gazes out of a window is the very picture of lonely contemplation, the immigrant housewife's fated lot as she paces her sterile and lushly-carpeted abode, cooks and cleans desultorily and keeps the radio playing all day to beat the resounding silence of a still-alien apartment.

It is a lot we have met many times before, however, and though some (trifling) things have changed, much remains the same. This is no longer a novel tale; and Kapur, despite a potentially-promising detour by way of Nina's self-righteous husband Ananda or "Andy" who turns out to be sexually-dysfunctional, has no real novel take on Indian immigrant existence in North America. Set in the 1970s, *The*

Immigrant reminds one of Bharati Mukherjee's stories written in that era, when she was hailed as a path-breaking teller of Indian immigrant women's tales in Canada and the USA. Mukherjee's *Wife* (1975) surely shares many of the same solitary spaces and sentiments of Kapur's Nina, and while this may endorse the historical veracity of both (and numerous other such) novels, it means that we are offered no new insights after 30 years of excavating the innards of female immigrant angst in Indian English Writing.

What redeems Kapur's novel, however, is its sure-footed trail around the locations of the novel with its female protagonist Nina—from the red-brick buildings of Miranda House in Delhi University, where she (like her creator) teaches English Literature, to the bright corridors of Dalhousie University in Halifax, where she pursues a degree in Library Science, en route to employment in the adopted country that will provide her with the

proverbial (and providential) ticket to ride. In between, there's life on the poor side in a tiny two-roomed New Delhi tenement with a long-widowed, long-suffering mother whose only remaining desire is to see her daughter "settled" into marriage and motherhood, and there's life on the cosy side in far-away Canada, in her newly-acquired husband's hard-earned home. What then finds our ears pricked (or rather, our eyes popped) is a whiff of vexation in Nina and Ananda's conjugal capers in the bedroom—if sex always sells, hindered sex is surely tumescent with the obligation to offer a surprise variant—and we are all primed to expect the unexpected.

Ironically enough, the complication of a sexually-dysfunctional husband and a frustrated new bride proves a limp one, for it turns out to be an imbroglio that is only mildly diverting in the final analysis. The most entertaining parts of it find Ananda in a secret sojourn to California for a frolicsome "hands-on" remedial therapy. The most disappointing part (re)produces an Ananda, who is almost miraculously cured of his affliction, a rejuvenated man who then bounces away to make up for lost time with the female species, including—though not exclusively—his wife. (The mandatory long blond hair on his pillow that Nina detects after returning from a trip to India is proof, after all, not merely of the success between the sheets, but also that he has finally "arrived" in the West.) Nina, meanwhile, has found herself a lover amongst her classmates. The lover does not last, but the liberatory bell has struck, and the denouement is incipient: Nina re-discovers herself on the freedom-friendly soil, and surges forward to forge a brand new identity. Why are we not surprised? ■



ON FAMILIAR GROUND: Kapur

VIVEK SINGH